

agitates him, his temper flares. Raising his hand to stop me speaking, he says: "I have no regrets about what I did, and the way I did it. Ask them to shoot me for this," he asserts, his thin lips clamped tight.

At this point, his thin innocuous body looks ominous, dangerous, like a living bomb. "How many like you are ready to kill in the name of jihad?" "I know only Shakeel and Nisar, Atif is dead, a few more," he replies. "There will be thousands willing to join the jihad," he adds as

quiet again, turning the idea in his mind. "If Allah wants, I will do so. *Meri valid ko jannat naseeb hogi* (my mother will be sent to paradise)," he replies. He looks almost as if under a spell, unthinking, unfeeling, a machine engineered to kill. All in the name of Allah. What's even more frightening is that many more like him could be out there.

■ Saquib Nisar, 23

A Jamia Millia Islamia graduate, now pursuing a management course from Sikkim Manipal University, accused of being part of the Ghaffar Market reconnaissance team.

Saquib Nisar is handcuffed, a policeman at his side. He is slim, fair with good looks, large, expressive eyes; his face looks tired for lack of sleep. He wears well-fitting blue jeans, a red and white bold striped shirt hangs loosely on his slim frame. He looks eager to talk despite having undergone hours of extensive police interrogation. One gets the impression that he belongs to a family of a certain level of affluence.

I ask him: "Do you know what you have done?" He remains static, head down, no movement to show he has heard the question. Then after a long pause, he looks up. "Yes," is the tentative reply. "Where did you plant the bomb?" "In CP," comes the answer. "Where in CP?" "Regal cinema," Nisar answers, his voice growing louder and clearer. "Did you know it was a bomb and doing this would kill innocent people?" "Yes." "Why did you do it?" He looks up and says, "For Allah. It's a jihad for Allah." His eyes seem moist, but it's not remorse.

He is forthcoming about his background, a Delhiite, not from Azamgarh, he insists. He did his schooling in Delhi and has just graduated in Political Science, Economics and Islamic Studies from Jamia Millia Islamia scoring reasonably well, "three year aggregate marks of 56 per cent", he says proudly. He had a life beyond jihad, a girl who was more than just a friend, and aspirations for everything that's usual for a guy of his age—clothes, girls and gadgets.

But, by his own admission, this lifestyle was just a cover to hide his real intent, his real passion—jihad in the name of Allah, for Allah. "I do not miss my girl, my life," he says, a little surprised how the police got to him so soon. "We lead a normal life of a student, beyond suspicion," he says, adding that he believed he would never be caught. "I have no criminal history."

Jihad was like a part-time activity that he pursued with utmost seriousness. Nisar used to meet a set of like-minded friends in college and

SAQUIB NISAR

"He (Atif) would talk about jihad for hours. He was quite passionate about it and infused the same in me."

"Allah does miracles to save a jihadi, that is true."

“Atif said one has to adopt evil to prevent a bigger one. It's not for me or you; it's for Allah.”

an afterthought. And what about the Indian Mujahideen? "I know only of Atif."

Prodding further, I ask, "When you went to Ahmedabad, didn't it bother you who paid for your travel?" He responds, "I knew there was someone very generous to us, he was a lover of Allah and was supporting us in all possible ways." "Did your parents know about it?" "Now they do," is the blunt reply. "My father is upset with me. He told me that I am not his son. He does not understand jihad for Allah, and nothing else matters to me."

Would he plant a bomb in the same market where his mother buys vegetables? He remains